

BACK IN COMMAND Himanta Biswa Sarma after the BJP's win, Guwahati, May 4

politically convenient formulation. "Politically, the NDA faces the delicate task of balancing strong central leadership with Assam's deeply rooted regional aspirations, particularly around identity, immigration and autonomy. Socially, managing ethnic and communal anxieties without sharpening polarisation will remain critical," says Dilip Gogoi, associate professor and head of the Department of Political Science at Cotton University, Guwahati.

This is where Sarma's land-reclamation agenda becomes politically significant. His government says it cleared 150,000 bighas of encroached land in the previous term and has now promised to reclaim another 500,000 bighas, placing the exercise firmly within the NDA's larger 'Jati, Mati, Bheti' (identity, land, home) pitch and its promise of defending indigeneity. Administratively, the state government can argue that it is freeing public, forest, grazing and institutional land for conservation, infrastructure and productive use. Politically, the exercise offers visible proof of action against what the BJP portrays as illegal occupation linked to demographic anxieties over Bangladeshi migrants.

Sarma will have to prove that his distinction between Indian Muslims and illegal immigrants is more than a political formulation

GRAPPLING WITH ECONOMIC REALITY

If Sarma's first term could be presented as a period of political consolidation, administrative speed, welfare expansion and infrastructure push, the second term will be judged by harder outcomes: jobs, incomes, industrial depth, human capital and inclusive growth.

According to RBI data, Assam recorded the fastest economic growth among states between 2021 and 2025 at 45 per cent, far above the national average of 29 per cent. The government says GSDP at current prices is projected at Rs 8.7 lakh crore in FY27, with a growth rate of 16.93 per cent, and that per capita income rose from Rs 86,947 in FY21 to Rs 1.8 lakh in FY26.

But the headline growth rate hides a slower story. Assam is still not among India's top 15 states by absolute GDP. Its per capita income remains among the bottom 10 in the country. A NITI Aayog macro-fiscal brief records that Assam's share in India's nominal GDP fell from 2.6 per cent in 1991 to 1.8 per cent in FY22. Manufacturing's contribution to State Value Added is 12.5 per cent, below the national figure of 14.8 per cent.

The fiscal architecture looks health-